

WAITING FOR CITIZENSHIP Matuas hold their community ID cards aloft at the Hari Chand temple, Barasat, West Bengal

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DELAYING THE CAA EMBRACE

Mindful of the TMC's unrelenting attacks on the CAA and the inflexible, must-have domicile proof requires by its rules, the Matua leadership decide on a watchful wait

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

The Matua community of West Bengal—who have long demanded formal Indian citizenship—has been the object of some assiduous courtship from the BJP in recent years. The legislative writ it enjoys at the Centre had allowed it to offer the Matuas a unique engagement ring: the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA). But amidst the ruction of a protracted poll season, the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) here has managed to put a spoke—rather, a spook—in the wheel by drawing attention to the law's fine print. Now the All India Matua Mahasangha, the community's umbrella outfit, led by Union minister and the BJP's Bongaon MP Shantanu Thakur, has informally asked its members to not apply for citizenship under the law until the Lok Sabha election is over.

The CAA seeks to fast-track citizenship for Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and Christians—controversially excluding Muslims—who entered India from Bangladesh, Afghanistan and Pakistan before December 31, 2014. As a community that fled persecution in East Pakistan/ Bangladesh, with the wounds of history still raw, the Matuas are drawn to the CAA's special value, material and symbolic. Mining that is a political priority for the BJP—beyond the Matua-dominated constituencies, it was a perfect recipe for overall Hindu consolidation. For the TMC, thwarting this project has its own charms, the 27 per cent Muslim electorate among them. If the TMC appears to control the ball currently, it has to do with the mechanics of the CAA—foggy as it is on a variety of points, including the delicate one of whether an applicant gets stripped back to an ab initio "foreigner" status by the very act of applying.

According to the government portal created for the purpose, an applicant must furnish a copy of one document establishing he or she was a resident of Afghanistan, Pakistan or Bangladesh. It is this condition—laid down under Schedule 1A of the rules notified in March—that can upset the community, Matua leaders say. Many of them do not have any document from their previous domicile in Bangladesh/ East Pakistan, from where they migrated to West Bengal during and after Partition and the 1971 India-Pakistan conflict. With the TMC confounding the air with the scaremongering line that those who register under the CAA would be singled out and targeted through the National Register of Citizens (NRC), the Mahasangha feels